

Cairn 2e Core Rulebook

Cairn (Second Edition): Core Rulebook

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Cairn (Second Edition): Core Rulebook

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Overview & Principles

Overview

Neutrality

The Warden's role is to act as a neutral arbiter and portray the rules, situations, non-player characters (NPCs), and narrative clearly.

Classless

A character's role or skills are not limited by a single class. Instead, the equipment they carry and their experiences define their specialty.

Death

Characters may be powerful, but they are also vulnerable to harm in its many forms. Death is always around the corner, but it is never random or without warning.

Fiction First

Dice do not always reflect an obstacle's difficulty or its outcome. Instead, success and failure are based on in-world elements and arbitrated by the Warden in dialogue with the players.

Growth

Characters are changed through in-world advancement, gaining new skills and abilities by surviving dangerous events and overcoming obstacles.

Player Choice

Players should always understand the reasons behind the choices they've made, and information about potential risks should be provided freely and frequently.

Principles

The Warden and the players each have guidelines that help foster a specific play experience defined by critical thinking, exploration, and an emergent narrative.

Shared Objectives

Players trust one another to engage with the shared setting, character goals, and party challenges. Therefore the party is typically working together towards a common goal, as a team.

Principles for Players

Agency

- Attributes and related saves do not define your character. They are tools.
- Don't ask only what your character would do; ask what you would do, too.
- Be creative with your intuition, items, and connections.

Teamwork

- Seek consensus from the other players before barreling forward.
- Stay on the same page about goals and limits, respecting each other and accomplishing more as a group than alone.

Exploration

- Asking questions and listening to detail is more useful than any stats, items, or skills you have.
- Take the Warden's description without suspicion, but don't shy away from seeking more information.
- There is no single correct way forward.

Talking

- Treat NPCs as if they were real people, and rely on your curiosity to safely gain information and solve problems.
- You'll find that most people are interesting and will want to talk things through before getting violent.

Caution

- Fighting is a choice and rarely a wise one; consider whether

- violence is the best way to achieve your goals.
- Try to stack the odds in your favor, and retreat when things seem unfavorable.

Planning

- Think of ways to avoid your obstacles through reconnaissance, subtlety, and fact-finding.
- Do some research, and ask around about your objectives.

Ambition

- Set goals, and use your meager means to take steps forward.
- Expect nothing. Earn your reputation.
- Keep things moving forward, and play to see what happens.

Principles for Wardens

Information

- Provide useful information about the game world as the characters explore it.
- Players do not need to roll dice to learn about their circumstances.
- Be helpful and direct with your answers to their questions.
- Respond honestly, describe consistently, and always let them know they can keep asking questions.

Difficulty

- Default to context and realism rather than numbers and mechanics.
- If something the players want to do is sincerely impossible, no roll will allow them to do it.
- Is what the player describes and how they leverage the situation sensible? Let it happen.
- Saves cover a great deal of uncertain situations and are often all that is necessary for risky actions.

Preparation

- The game world is organic, malleable and random. It intuitively and makes sharp turns.
- Use random tables and generators to develop situations, not stories or plots.
- NPCs remember what the PCs say and do, and how they affect the world.
- NPCs don't want to die. Infuse their own self-interest and will to live into every personality.

Narrative Focus

- Emergent experience of play is what matters, not math or character abilities. Give the players weapon trainers and personal quests to facilitate improvement and specialization.
- Pay attention to the needs and wants of the players, then put realistic opportunities in their path.
- A dagger to your throat will kill you, regardless of your expensive armor and impressive training.

Danger

- The game world produces real risk of pain and death for the player characters.
- Telegraph serious danger to players when it is present. The more dangerous, the more obvious.
- Put traps in plain sight and let the players take time to figure out a solution.
- Give players opportunities to solve problems and interact with the world.

Treasure

- A Treasure is specific to the environment from where it is recovered. It tells a story.
- Treasure is highly valuable, almost always bulky, and rarely useful beyond its worth and prestige.
- Relics are not Treasure, though they are useful and interesting.
- Use Treasure as a lure to exotic locations under the protection of intimidating foes.

Choice

- Give players a solid choice to force outcomes when the situation lulls.
- Use binary "so, A or B?" responses when their intentions are vague.
- Work together using this conversational method to keep the game moving.
- Ensure that the player character's actions leave their mark on the game world.

Die of Fate

- Occasionally you will want an element of randomness (e.g. the weather, unique character knowledge, etc.).
- In these situations, roll 1d6. A roll of 4 or more generally favors the players.
- A roll of 3 or under tends to mean bad luck for the PCs or their allies.

Character Creation

Roll or choose a Background

- First, roll or choose from the [Backgrounds](#) table below and note the page number. You will refer to that page for the next few steps.
- Choose a name from the available list, then record each of your character's starting items. See [Inventory](#) and [Inventory Slots](#) for how to record items.
- Roll on each of the included tables in the background. Record your character's items, skills, or abilities from each result. Some backgrounds may ask you to refer to the tables in the [Marketplace](#) as well.

Backgrounds

d20 Background

1	<u>Aurifex</u>	11	<u>Half-Witch</u>
2	<u>Barber-Surgeon</u>	12	<u>Hexenbane</u>
3	<u>Beast Handler</u>	13	<u>Jongleur</u>
4	<u>Bonekeeper</u>	14	<u>Kettlewright</u>
5	<u>Cutpurse</u>	15	<u>Marchguard</u>
6	<u>Fieldwarden</u>	16	<u>Mountebank</u>
7	<u>Fletchwind</u>	17	<u>Outrider</u>
8	<u>Foundling</u>	18	<u>Prowler</u>
9	<u>Fungal Forager</u>	19	<u>Rill Runner</u>
10	<u>Greenwise</u>	20	<u>Scrivener</u>

Attributes, Hit Protection, and Traits

- Roll for your Characters **Attributes** and **Hit Protection**.
- Roll for the rest of your character's Traits, and then on the the Bonds table.
- Finally, roll for your character's **Age** (2d20+10). If you are the *youngest* character, roll on the Omens table. The result should be read aloud to the other players. The Warden should incorporate Omens into the setting as they see fit.

Attributes

- Player Characters have just three Attributes: (**Strength (STR)**, **Dexterity (DEX)**, and **Willpower (WIL)**).
- Roll 3d6 for each of your character's **Attributes**, in order. You may then swap any two of the results.
- Attributes are not universal descriptors. A character with a low STR is not necessarily hopelessly weak; they can still attempt to lift a heavy door or survive a deadly fight! Their risk is simply higher.

Hit Protection

- Roll 1d6 to determine your PC's starting **Hit Protection** (HP), which reflects their ability to avoid damage in combat. It does not indicate a character's health or fortitude, nor do they lose it for very long. See Healing & Recovery.
- If an attack would take a PC's HP exactly to 0, the player must roll on the Scars table.

Inventory

- Characters have a total of ten inventory slots but can only carry four or five items comfortably without the help of bags, backpacks, horses, carts, etc.
- Each PC starts with a **Backpack** that can hold up to six slots of items or **Fatigue**. Carts (which must be pulled with both hands), horses, or mules can make a huge difference in how much a PC can bring with them on an adventure. **Hirelings** can also be paid to carry equipment.
- Inventory is abstract, dependent only on the fiction as adjudicated by the Warden. Anyone carrying a full inventory (i.e. filling all 10

slots) is reduced to 0 HP. A character cannot fill more than ten slots.

Inventory Slots

- Most items take up one slot unless otherwise indicated.
- *Petty* items do not take up any slots. *Bulky* items take up **two** slots.
- A bag of coins worth less than 100gp is *petty* and does not occupy a slot.

Character Traits (d10)

Physique

1	Athletic	6	Scrawny
2	Brawny	7	Short
3	Flabby	8	Statuesque
4	Lanky	9	Stout
5	Rugged	10	Towering

Skin

1	Birthmarked	6	Soft
2	Marked	7	Tanned
3	Oily	8	Tattooed
4	Rosy	9	Weathered
5	Scarred	10	Webbed

Hair

1	Bald	6	Long
2	Braided	7	Luxurious
3	Curly	8	Oily
4	Filthy	9	Wavy
5	Frizzy	10	Wispy

Face

1	Bony	6	Perfect
2	Broken	7	Rakish
3	Chiseled	8	Sharp
4	Elongated	9	Square
5	Pale	10	Sunken

Speech

1	Blunt	6	Gravelly
2	Booming	7	Precise
3	Cryptic	8	Squeaky
4	Droning	9	Stuttering

Clothing

1	Antique	6	Frayed
2	Bloody	7	Frumpy
3	Elegant	8	Livery
4	Filthy	9	Rancid
5	Foreign	10	Soiled

Virtue

1	Ambitious	6	Honorable
2	Cautious	7	Humble
3	Courageous	8	Merciful
4	Disciplined	9	Serene
5	Gregarious	10	Tolerant

Vice

1	Aggressive	6	Lazy
2	Bitter	7	Nervous
3	Craven	8	Rude
4	Deceitful	9	Vain
5	Greedy	10	Vengeful

Bonds

D20 Bond

- 1 You inherited a **Single Gem** (500gp, cold and brittle) from a long-dead relative. It arrived with a warning: squander your newfound riches, and a debt long thought forgotten would be called in.
 - 2 A distant cousin left you a small inheritance. Take **20Gp** and a **Strange Compass** (*petty*) that always points towards something deep in the Wood.
 - 3 You carry a **Portrait** in a locket (*petty*) of a past love who disappeared into the Wood long ago. Somehow you know that they are still alive.
 - 4 You found a **Tiny Crystal Prism** (*petty*) buried in the dirt. When held up to the light, it shows visions of an unknown location deep within the Wood. Sometimes you feel a presence looking back at you.
 - 5 You once freed a Naiad from a choked stream. In return, it gave you some **Silver Moss** (*petty*). Swallow it near water, and the creature will come, once, to repay its debt.
 - 6 You inherited an old **Journal**, bound in bark. Each evening, its pages are filled with the events of the day, crassly written from the journal's perspective. The writing is crude but accurate.
- You protect a long-dormant family secret. Take one half of an

- 7 **Ancient Key** (*petty*). They say that if joined with its twin, it opens a **Gate** through any door.
- 8 You received a **Letter** (*petty*) detailing incontrovertible proof that your true parentage is that of Fae nobility. The note also indicates a date and location where you are to meet the letter's author, deep in the the Wood.
- 9 You owe a great debt to a member of the nobility and carry their **Signet Ring** (*petty*), which serves as proof of their protection as well as your obligation.
- 10 You consumed a **Mischievous Spirit** that wreaks havoc on your insides, demanding to be taken home, deep in the Wood. It occupies one slot but absorbs one **Fatigue** each day. It wants you alive (for now).
- 11 A roaming storyteller once spun you tales of great treasure hidden deep in the Wood. You thought it naught but fancy, till they gave you **A Rolled-Up Map** (*petty*) marked with an X.
- 12 During your travels, you met a dying hunter who asked you to deliver a message to their loved ones. Take a **Letter** (*petty*), sealed with tree sap. It is addressed only to the **Lord Of Winter**.
- 13 You found a wounded beast in the forest but chose to ignore it. You see it everywhere now, but only when you're alone. It looks sad but not angry. You cannot become *panicked* when acting alone.
- 14 You promised a childhood friend that you'd bring them back a rare gift, something unique in all the world. Take a **Bracelet** (*petty*) woven from twine and wildflowers.
- 15 You crossed a creature of the Wood, and it cursed you with a **Stone Heart**. With each passing month, the stone grows heavier by one slot. Until your debt is lifted, you cannot truly die.
- 16 You carved a **Whistle** (*petty*) from an **Oak Lord's** branch. Your act did not go unnoticed. You cannot seem to rid yourself of the whistle either.
- 17 The **Dawn Brigade** did your family a service, giving you a dried **Blood-Red Flower** (*petty*) as proof. When the flower turns white, it means the favor is owed.
- 18 An entertainer once visited your home, filling it with story and song. He left one day without a word, leaving behind only **A Miniature Lute**. Something rattles inside.
- 19 A white crow appeared to you in a dream, holding a twig in its mouth. You awoke the next morning with the **Twig** (*petty*) in your hand. You believe it brings you luck. It smells faintly of sulfur.
- 20 One of your ancestors wronged a **Moss Witch**, who cursed their bloodline. Your visage causes mirrors to shatter. You've noticed that the shards can sometimes reveal illusions.
-

Omens

d20 Omen

- 1 The once rich waters of a life-giving river have turned black and putrid, tainting the land and sickening those who drink from it. A village elder points to some recent desecration as the cause, but most do not heed their words.
- It feels like winter has arrived too quickly this year, frost and

- 2 snows making their appearance much earlier than expected. There is talk of a pattern to the frost found in windows, ponds, and cracks in the ground. It almost looks like a map.
- 3 A thick, unnatural fog has begun encroaching upon an ancient and holy grove. It is said to be the work of a great forest spirit, angered by nearby deforestation.
- 4 The night sky grows dimmer each evening, as if stars are disappearing one by one. Rumors of hellish creatures capturing farmers and pulling them into the Roots are spreading like wildfire. Village elders believe the two are connected.
- 5 The songbirds of the Wood have fallen eerily silent as of late. Hunters claim that a spectral figure has been spotted wandering the forest, gazing longingly at anyone it encounters.
- 6 Strange, tear-shaped stones have been found throughout the region, sparking a "gold rush" of sorts for jewelers and thieves alike. The locals believe they are the tears of the earth itself, weeping for a great tragedy yet to come.
- 7 Swarming pests gnaw away at the edges of dreams, and farmers speak of a loud buzzing sound emanating from deep within the Wood. They also say that the sound is getting closer.
- 8 There is a village known far and wide for its impressive "mother tree," said to shelter the town's secrets in its boughs. Recently it has begun bleeding red sap, worrying the elders.
- 9 The moon turns a deep crimson, bathing the night in an eerie, blood-red light. Some say it heralds a time of chaos and strife, as the boundaries between the Wood and the mortal realm grow thin.
- 10 Strange cracks have appeared in the night sky, revealing a swirling vortex of light and color. Some say that the divide between realms is at its weakest in centuries and fear what may emerge from the other side.
- 11 A night-blooming flower once thought extinct is sprouting up throughout the Wood. Its scent is intoxicating but also causes vivid nightmares.
- 12 Local livestock have grown increasingly agitated and unmanageable as of late. An old shepherd says it is due to an unsettling howl that emanates from the Wood each full moon.
- 13 Swarms of insects are fleeing from the Wood in droves, destroying any wooden structures they come across. The sound of their wings hum a familiar tune as they pass overhead, like a forgotten nursery rhyme.
- 14 Hunters talk of a curse that befalls any who kill a beast with a streak of white fur: soon after, they are found dead in their homes. Each day, there are fewer and fewer creatures to hunt.
- 15 Folks say that a faint laughter can be heard echoing out of wells all over the city, and that the echoes change to sobs at night.
- 16 The constellations have slowly started shifting in the night sky, forming unfamiliar patterns that have stargazers and sages perplexed. Even the animals seem disturbed.
- 17 An ancient tree at the heart of a sleepy village has suddenly withered and died, despite showing no signs of disease. After its trunk was cut, a bloody hand was found in its core.
- 18 Statues have been weeping blood for months on end, and the wombs of the village have lain barren since. A single child has been the only exception, hidden away by elders overcome with

fear and dread.

- 19 The local fauna is behaving oddly, displaying heightened aggression or fleeing the area entirely. Hunters talk of a shadowy figure that roams the Wood, calling to the animals.

- 20 Border towns have become riotous in recent weeks after multiple claims of a red-robed figure appearing in their children's dreams, uttering the same warning: A fire is coming, and it will consume everything.
-

Core Rules

Attributes

Each of the three **Attributes** are used in different circumstances. (See **Saves**, below.)

- **Strength (STR)**: Used for saves requiring physical power, like lifting gates, bending bars, resisting poison, etc.
- **Dexterity (DEX)**: Used for saves requiring poise, speed, reflexes, dodging, climbing, sneaking, balancing, etc.
- **Willpower (WIL)**: Used for saves to persuade, deceive, interrogate, intimidate, charm, provoke, manipulate spells, etc.

Saves

- A save is a roll to avoid negative outcomes from risky choices. Characters roll a d20 and compare the results to the appropriate attribute. If they roll equal to or under that attribute, they succeed. Otherwise, they fail. A 1 is always a success, and a 20 is always a failure.
- If two opponents are each trying to overcome the other, whoever is most at risk should save.
- If two characters need to take an action together, whoever is most at risk should save (usually the character with the lowest relevant Attribute).

Healing & Recovery

- Resting for a few moments and having a drink of water restores lost HP but may leave the party exposed. Bandages can stabilize a character that has taken critical damage.
- Attribute loss (see **Critical Damage**) can usually be restored with a week's rest, facilitated by a healer or other appropriate source of expertise.
- Some healing services are free, while magical or more expedient means of recovery may come at a cost.

Deprivation & Fatigue

- A PC that lacks a crucial need (such as food or rest) is **Deprived**. Anyone **Deprived** for more than a day adds **Fatigue** to their inventory, one for each day. A **Deprived** PC cannot recover HP, Attributes, or item slots from **Fatigue**.
- A PC may also be forced to add **Fatigue** after casting spells or due to events occurring in the fiction. Each Fatigue occupies one slot

and lasts until the PC is able to recuperate (such as with a full night's rest in a safe spot).

- If a character is forced to add **Fatigue** to their inventory but they have no free slots, they must drop an item from their inventory.

Armor

- Before calculating damage to HP, subtract the target's **Armor** value from the result of damage rolls.
- Shields and similar armor provide a bonus defense (e.g. +1 Armor), but only while the item is held or worn. Some may also provide additional benefits, depending on the fiction.
- A PC, NPC, or monster cannot have more than 3 Armor.

Reactions

When the PCs encounter an NPC whose reaction to the party is not obvious, the Warden may roll 2d6 and consult the following table:

2	3-5	6-8	9-11	12
Hostile	Wary	Curious	Kind	Helpful

Morale

- Enemies must pass a WIL save to avoid fleeing when they take their first casualty and again when they lose half their number.
- Some groups may use their leader's WIL in place of their own. Lone foes must save when they're reduced to 0 HP.
- Morale does not affect PCs.

Hirelings

- Adventuring parties can recruit hirelings, relying on their unique skills, knowledge, and training to aid in expeditions.
- To create a hireling, choose an appropriate role from the [Hirelings](#) table in the Marketplace. Roll 3d6 for each attribute and 1d6 for their HP. Give them **equipment** appropriate to their station, then roll on the Character Traits tables to further flesh them out.
- Alternatively, choose an appropriate **background** and **name** from the [Character Creation](#) guide. Roll (or choose from) the tables for that background. Then roll for Rations, Gold Pieces, Attributes, HP, and age.

Die of Fate

- Optionally, roll 1d6 whenever the outcome of an event is uncertain or to simulate an element of randomness and chance.
- A roll of 4 or more generally favors the PCs, while a roll of 3 or under usually means bad luck for the PCs.

Combat

Rounds

- A **Round** is roughly ten seconds of in-game time and proceeds with each side taking turns. Each round starts with any PC that is able to act, followed by their opponents. *The result of each side's actions occur simultaneously.*
- During the *first round of combat*, each PC must make a DEX save in order to act. Special circumstances, abilities, items, or skills may negate this requirement. PCs that fail their save *lose their turn* for this round.
- Their opponents then take their turn, and the first round ends. The next round begins with the PCs taking their turn, followed by their opponents, and so on until combat has ended with one side defeated or fled.

Actions

On their turn, a character may move up to 40ft and take up to one action. This may be casting a spell, attacking, moving for a second time, or some other reasonable action. Each round, the PCs declare what they are doing before dice are rolled. If a character attempts something risky, the Warden calls for a save for appropriate players or NPCs.

Attacking & Damage

- The attacker rolls their weapon die and subtracts the target's armor, then deals the remaining total to their opponent's HP. Attacks in combat automatically hit.
- If multiple attackers target the same foe, roll all damage dice and keep the single highest result. All actions are declared before being resolved.
- If an attack would take a PC's HP exactly to 0, refer to the Scars table to see how they are uniquely impacted.

Attack Modifiers

- If fighting from a position of weakness (such as through cover or with bound hands), the attack is *Impaired*, and the attacker must roll 1d4 damage regardless of the attacks damage die. Unarmed attacks always do d4 damage.
- If fighting from a position of advantage (such as against a helpless foe or through a daring maneuver), the attack is *Enhanced*, allowing the attacker to roll 1d12 damage instead of their normal die.
- Attacks with the *Blast* quality affect all targets in the noted area, rolling separately for each affected character. This can be anything from explosions to a dragon's breath or the impact of a meteorite. If unsure how many targets can be affected, *roll the related damage die for a result.*
- If attacking with two weapons at the same time, roll both damage dice and keep the single highest result (denoted with a plus symbol, e.g. d8+d8).

Critical Damage

- Damage that reduces a target's HP below zero is subtracted *from their STR* by the amount of damage remaining. The target must then immediately make a STR save to avoid taking **Critical Damage**, using their *new STR score*. On a success, the target is still in the fight (albeit with a lower STR score) and must continue to make critical damage saves when incurring damage.
- Any PC that suffers Critical Damage cannot do anything but crawl

weakly, grasping for life. If given aid (such as bandages), they will stabilize. If left untreated, they die within the hour. NPCs and monsters that fail a Critical Damage save are considered dead, per the **Warden's** discretion. Additionally, some enemies will have special abilities or effects that are triggered when their target fails a critical damage save.

Attribute Loss

- If a PC takes damage outside of combat, they should instead receive damage to an Attribute, typically STR.
- If a PC's STR is reduced to 0, they die. If their DEX is reduced to 0, they are paralyzed. If their WIL is reduced to 0, they are delirious. Complete DEX and WIL loss renders the character unable to act until they are restored through extended rest or by extraordinary means.

Character Death

- When a character dies, the player should create a new character or take control of a hireling. They immediately join the party in order to reduce downtime.

Detachments

- Large groups of similar combatants fighting together are treated as a single *Detachment*. When a *detachment* takes **Critical Damage**, it is routed or significantly weakened. When it reaches 0 STR, it is destroyed.
- Attacks against detachments by individuals are *impaired* (excluding *blast* damage). Attacks against individuals by detachments are *enhanced* and deal *blast* damage.

Retreat

- Running away from a dire situation always requires a successful DEX save, as well as a safe destination to run to.

Ranged Attacks

- Ranged weapons can target any enemy near enough to see the whites of their eyes. Attacks against especially distant targets are *Impaired*.
- Ammunition is not tracked unless otherwise specified.

Scars

If damage to a PC would reduce their HP to exactly 0, look up the result on the table below based on the *amount of HP lost in the attack*. For example, if a PC went from 3 HP to 0 HP, they would look at entry #3 (Walloped).

Scars Table

HP Lost	Result
1	Lasting Scar: Roll 1d6. 1: Neck, 2: Hands, 3: Eye, 4: Chest, 5: Legs, 6: Ear. Roll 1d6. If the total is higher than your max HP,

- take the new result.
- 2 Rattling Blow: You're disoriented and shaken. Describe how you refocus. Roll 1d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
- 3 Walloped: You're sent flying and land flat on your face, winded. You are deprived until you rest for a few hours. Then, roll 1d6. Add that amount to your max HP.
- 4 Broken Limb: Roll 1d6. 1-2: Leg, 3-4: Arm, 5: Rib, 6: Skull. Once mended, roll 2d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
- 5 Diseased: You're afflicted with a gross, uncomfortable infection. When you get over it, roll 2d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
- 6 Reorienting Head Wound: Roll 1d6. 1-2: STR, 3-4: DEX, 5-6: WIL. Roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your current attribute, take the new result.
- 7 Hamstrung: You can barely move until you get serious help and rest. After recovery, roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max DEX, take the new result.
- 8 Deafened: You cannot hear anything until you find extraordinary aid. Regardless, make a WIL save. If you pass, increase your max WIL by 1d4.
- 9 Re-brained: Some hidden part of your psyche is knocked loose. Roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max WIL, take the new result.
- 10 Sundered: An appendage is torn off, crippled, or useless. (The Warden will tell you which.) Then make a WIL save. If you pass, increase your max WIL by 1d6.
- 11 Mortal Wound: You are deprived and out of action. You die in one hour unless healed. Upon recovery, roll 2d6. Take the new result as your max HP.
- 12 Doomed: Death seemed ever so close, but somehow you survived. If your next save against critical damage is a fail, you die horribly. If you pass, roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
-

Magic

Spellbooks

- **Spellbooks** contain a single spell and take up one slot. They cannot be easily transcribed or created; instead they are recovered from places like tombs, dungeons, and manors.
- Spellbooks sometimes display unusual properties or limitations, such as producing a foul or unearthly smell when opened, possessing an innate intelligence, or being legible only when held in moonlight.
- Spellbooks will attract the attention of those who seek the arcane power within, and it is considered dangerous to display them openly.

Casting Spells

- Anyone can cast a spell by holding a Spellbook in both hands and reading its contents aloud. They must then add a **Fatigue** to inventory.
- Given time and safety, PCs can *enhance* a spell's impact (e.g.,

affecting multiple targets, increasing its power, etc.) without any additional cost.

- If the PC is *deprived* or in danger (such as during combat), the Warden may require a PC to make a WIL save to avoid any ill-effects from casting the spell. Consequences of failure are on par with the intended effect and may result in added **Fatigue**, the destruction of the Spellbook, injury, and even death.

Scrolls

Scrolls are similar to Spellbooks, however:

- They are *petty*.
- They do not cause **Fatigue**.
- They disappear after one use.

Relics

Relics are items imbued with a magical spell or power. They do not cause Fatigue. Relics usually have limited use, as well as a **Recharge** condition.

Procedures

Dungeon Exploration

The Basics

- The dungeon exploration cycle (see below) is divided into a series of **Turns**, **Actions**, and their consequences.
- On their **turn**, a character can move a distance equal to their torchlight's perimeter (about 40ft), and perform one **action**. Players can use their **action** to move up to three times that distance though that will increase the chance of triggering a roll on the **Dungeon Events** table.
- The **Warden** should present obvious information about an area and its dangers freely and at no cost. Moving quickly or without caution may increase the chance of encountering a wandering monster, springing a trap, or triggering a roll on the **Dungeon Events** table.

Although the term "dungeon" is used here, it can mean any dangerous locale (mansions, farmhouses, adventure site, etc).

Dungeon Exploration Cycle

1. The **Warden** describes the party's surroundings and any immediate dangers (combat, traps, surprises, etc.). The players then declare their character's intended movements and **actions**.
2. The Warden resolves the **actions** of each character simultaneously, along with any **actions** that are already in progress. Remember, the Die of Fate can be a useful tool whenever the Warden is in doubt!
3. The players record any loss of resources and any new conditions (i.e. item use, *deprivation*, etc). The cycle then begins again. If appropriate, the **Warden** should roll on the **Dungeon Events** table. Keep common sense in mind when interpreting the results!

Dungeon Events

Exploring a dungeon is always dangerous, and time must always be weighed against the risk of awakening the location's denizens, natural hazards, and worse.

When the party:

- Spends more than one dungeon cycle in a single room or location
- Moves quickly or haphazardly through a room
- Moves into a new area, level, or zone
- Creates a loud disturbance

Roll on the table below.

1	Encounter	Roll on an encounter table. Possibly hostile . (See Reactions .)
2	Sign	A clue, spoor, track, abandoned lair, scent, victim, etc is discovered.
3	Environment	Surroundings shift or escalate. Water rises, ceilings collapse, a ritual nears completion, etc.
4	Loss	Torches are blown out, an ongoing spell fizzles, etc. The party must resolve the effect before moving on.
5	Exhaustion	The party must rest (triggering another roll on this table), add a Fatigue , or consume a ration.
6	Quiet	The party is left alone (and safe) for the time being.

Actions

- **Actions** are any non-passive activities, such as *searching for traps*, *forcing open a door*, *listening for danger*, *disarming a trap*, *engaging an enemy in combat*, *casting a spell*, *dodging a trap*, *running away*, *resting*, etc.
- Some **actions** have special rules (see below), while others may take multiple **turns** to complete.
- Loud or noticeable **actions** may also trigger an **encounter** with the dungeon's denizens.

Searching

- A character can spend a **turn** performing an *exhaustive* search of **one** object or location in an area, revealing any relevant hidden treasure, traps, secret doors, etc.
- Larger rooms and difficult or complex dungeon terrain may take a few **turns** to properly search.
- Searching a room *first* is a safer way to explore the dungeon, but it has a steep cost: time.

Resting

- A character can spend a turn **resting** to restore all **HP**.
- A light source and a *safe location* are required to **rest**. Present or oncoming danger makes **rest** impossible.
- **Resting** does not restore **Fatigue**, as it is impossible to safely **Make Camp** in a dungeon.

Panic

- A character that is surrounded by enemies, enveloped by darkness, or facing their greatest fears may experience *panic*. A **WIL save** is typically required to avoid losing control and becoming *panicked*.
- A *panicked* character must make a **WIL save** to overcome their condition as an **action** on their **turn**.
- A *panicked* character has 0 **HP**, does not act in the first round of combat, and all of their attacks are *impaired*.

Dungeon Elements

Light

- Torches and other radial sources of light illuminate 40ft of dungeon and beyond that only a dim outline of objects. Torches last until they are put out by a character or their environment.
- A torch can be lit 3 times before permanently degrading. A lantern can be relit 6 times per oil can, but requires more inventory slots.
- Characters without a light source may suffer from *panic* until their situation is remedied.

Doors

- Doors and entryways may be locked, stuck, or blocked entirely. Characters can try to force a door open (or wedge it shut) using available resources (spikes, glue) or through raw ability.
- The party's marching order determines who is most impacted by whatever lies beyond a door.
- A character can detect, through careful observation (listening, smelling, etc.), signs of life and other hazards through nearby doors and walls.

Traps

- A cautious character should be presented with any and all information that would allow them the opportunity to *avoid* springing a trap. An unwitting character will trigger a trap according to the fiction, or otherwise will have a 2-in-6 chance.
- **Traps** can usually be detected by carefully **searching** a room.
- Damage from traps is taken from Attributes (usually **STR** or **DEX**) and *not* from **HP**. Armor can reduce damage, but only if applicable (e.g. a shield would not reduce damage from noxious gas).

Wilderness Exploration

Watches

- A day is divided into three **watches**, called *morning*, *afternoon*, and *night*.
- Each character can choose *one* **Wilderness Action** per **watch**.
- If the characters split up, each group is treated as an independent entity.

Points

- Potential destinations on a map are called **points**.
- One or more **watches** may be required to journey between two **points** on a map, depending on the path, terrain, weather, and party status.
- The party has a rough idea of the challenges involved to get to

their destination, but rarely any specifics.

Travel Duration

Travel time in Cairn is counted in watches, divided into three eight-hour segments per day. However, as most parties elect to spend the third watch of the day resting, one can use "days" as a shorthand for travel time.

To determine the distance between two points, combine all penalties from the path, terrain, and weather difficulty tables, taking into account any changes to those elements along the route. For travel via waterways, refer to the surrounding terrain difficulty. For especially vast terrain, assign a penalty of up to +2 watches to the journey.

The weather, terrain, darkness, injured party members, and other obstacles can impact travel or even make it impossible! In some cases, the party may need to add **Fatigue** or expend resources in order to sustain their pace. Mounts, guides, and maps can increase the party's travel speed or even negate certain penalties.

Path Difficulty

Path	Penalty	Odds of Getting Lost
Roads	None	None
Trails	+1 Watch	2-in-6
Wilderness	+2 Watches	3-in-6

Path Distance	Penalty
Short	+1 Watch
Medium	+2 Watches
Long	+3 Watches

Terrain Difficulty

Difficulty	Terrain	Penalty	Factors
Easy	Plains, plateaus, valleys	none	Safe areas for rest, fellow travelers, good visibility
Tough	Forests, deserts, hills	+1 Watch	Wild animals, flooding, broken equipment, falling rocks, unsafe shelters, hunter's traps
Perilous	Mountains, jungles, swamp	+2 Watches	Quicksand, sucking mud, choking vines, unclean water, poisonous plants and animals, poor navigation

Weather

Each day, the Warden should roll on the weather table for the appropriate season. If the "**Extreme**" weather result is rolled twice in a row, the weather turns to "**Catastrophic**". A squall becomes a hurricane, a storm floods the valley, etc.

Weather Type

d6	Spring	Summer	Fall	Winter
1	Nice	Nice	Fair	Fair
2	Fair	Nice	Fair	Unpleasant
3	Fair	Fair	Unpleasant	Inclement
4	Unpleasant	Unpleasant	Inclement	Inclement
5	Inclement	Inclement	Inclement	Extreme
6	Extreme	Extreme	Extreme	Extreme

Weather Difficulty

Weather	Effect	Examples
Nice	Favorable conditions for travel.	<i>Clear skies, sunny</i>
Fair	Favorable conditions for travel.	<i>Overcast, breezy</i>
Unpleasant	Add a Fatigue or add one watch to the journey.	<i>Gusting winds, rain showers, sweltering heat, chill air</i>
Inclement	Add a Fatigue or add +1 watch . Increase terrain Difficulty by a step.	<i>Thunderstorms, lightning, rain, muddy ground</i>
Extreme	Add a Fatigue and add +1 watch . Increase terrain Difficulty by a step.	<i>Blizzards, freezing winds, flooding, mud slides</i>
Catastrophic	Most parties cannot travel under these conditions.	<i>Tornados, tidal waves, hurricane, volcanic eruption</i>

Wilderness Exploration Cycle

1. The **Warden** describes the current **point** or **region** on the map and how the path, weather, terrain, or party status might affect **travel speed**. The party plots or adjusts a given course towards their destination.
2. Each party member chooses a single **Wilderness Action**. The **Warden** narrates the results and then rolls on the **Wilderness Events** table. The party responds to the results.
3. The **players** and the **Warden** record any loss of resources and new conditions (i.e. torch use, *deprivation*, etc), and the cycle repeats.

Wilderness Events

1 Encounter	Roll on an encounter table for that terrain type or location. Don't forget to roll for NPC <u>reactions</u> if applicable.
2 Sign	The party discovers a clue, spoor, or indication of a nearby encounter, locality, hidden feature, or information about a nearby area.
3 Environment	A shift in weather or terrain.
4 Loss	The party is faced with a choice that costs them a resource (rations, tools, etc), time, or effort.
5 Exhaustion	The party encounters a barrier, forcing effort, care or delays. This might mean spending extra time (and an additional Wilderness Action) or adding Fatigue to the PC's inventory to

represent their difficulties.

- 6 Discovery** The party finds food, treasure, or other useful resources. The **Warden** can instead choose to reveal the primary feature of the area.
-

Wilderness Elements

Night

- The party can choose to travel during the night and rest during the day, but night travel is far slower and more treacherous!
- Traveling at night is always more dangerous! The **Warden** should roll *twice* on the **Wilderness Events** table.
- Some terrain and weather may be easier to traverse at night (desert, for example). The **Warden** should balance these challenges along with any other.

Sleep

- The last **watch** of the day is typically reserved for the **Make Camp** action.
- Characters typically need to sleep each day. Anything beyond a minor interruption can negate or cancel the benefits of sleep.
- If the party skips the **Make Camp** action, they each add a **Fatigue** to their inventory and are *deprived*. Additionally, traveling when sleep-deprived raises the terrain **Difficulty** by a step (i.e. *Easy* becomes *Tough*).

Light

- Torches and other radial sources of light illuminate 40ft ahead of the party, but beyond that only provides a dim outline of objects.
- Characters without a light source may suffer from *panic* until their situation is remedied.
- Environmental conditions (sudden gusts of wind, dust, water, etc.) can easily blow out a torch.

Light Sources

- A torch can be lit 3 times before degrading.
- A lantern can be relit indefinitely but requires a separate oil can (6 uses).

Wilderness Actions

Travel

- Travel begins. Obvious locations, features, and terrain of nearby areas are revealed according to their distance. This action is typically taken by the entire party as one.
- The party rolls 1d6 to see if they get lost along the way. This risk can increase or decrease, depending on path **Difficulty**, maps, party skills, and guides.
- If lost, the party may need to spend a **Wilderness Action** to recover their way. Otherwise, the party reaches the next **point** along their route.

Remember to compare the results of getting lost to the relevant path **Difficulty**.

Explore

- One or more party members search a large area, searching for hidden features, scouting ahead, or treading carefully.
- A Location (shelter, village, cave, etc.) or Feature (geyser, underground river, beached ship, etc.) is discovered.
- The **Travel** action is still required to *leave* the current area, even if it has been completely explored.

Supply

- One or more party members may hunt, fish, or forage for food, collecting 1d4 **Rations** (3 uses each). The chance of a greater bounty increases with each additional participant (e.g. 1d4 becomes 1d6, up to a maximum of 1d12).
- Relevant experience or equipment may also increase the bounty collected.
- The party may encounter homes and small villages, spending gold and a full **watch** to resupply.

Make Camp

- The party stops to set up camp in the wilds. Each party member (and their mounts) consumes a **Ration**.
- A **lookout rotation** is set so that the party can sleep unmolested. A smaller party may need to risk sleeping unguarded or switch off sleeping over multiple days.
- Party members that were able to rest remove all of **Fatigue** from their inventory.

Downtime

Between game sessions, players can engage in a variety of activities such as research, following up on leads, improving skills, or building relationships. A PC is limited to one **Downtime Action** at a time. These actions cannot be undertaken in unsafe conditions or while a character is in recovery. A character cannot perform an action if it would put their safety at risk.

Milestones

For activities requiring multiple steps, the **Warden** assigns 1-5 **Milestones** for players to track progress. Each **Milestone** represents a comprehensive, non-interactive task. The **Warden** may present different strategies to achieve these goals, each with distinct **Milestones**. Depending on the unfolding events in the game, the **Warden** is also empowered to introduce new **Milestones** or discard existing ones.

Costs

PCs can complete individual **Milestones** by taking a **Downtime Action** and paying its respective **Cost**. If a character is unable to pay the **Cost**, they may have to find some other way to achieve their goal. A few examples of **Cost**:

- **Gold**: Direct payment of gold from a character's inventory.
- **Resources**: Non-monetary costs such as material goods, specific common items, and so on.

- **Reputation:** Betting on a character's renown, personality, presence, social connections, etc.
- **Loss:** Offering something specific and unique. A finger, a soul, a **Relic**, etc.

Some **Costs** can be reduced or disregarded through character skills, connections, or force of will. For example, a PC may have already acquired the necessary reputation to gain access to a renowned institution, and thus the **cost** is abated. On the other hand, another character may not be so lucky and must rely on their force of personality instead. In this case, the Warden should state the risk (a permanent ban on entry, a loss of reputation, etc.). The PC then makes a **WIL** save; on a success, the cost is either reduced or avoided entirely.

Downtime Actions

The following activities represent some of the most common **Downtime Actions** a players can choose. The **Warden** can also create custom actions based on the needs of play.

Research

A PC investigates a question about a bit of lost or forgotten lore, the location of a lost item, the whereabouts of an important NPC, and so on. To take this action, the player must have a clearly formulated question they'd like to answer and a **Source** of knowledge in the game world that their character can interact with. If the PC does not have a **Source**, then they can spend a **Downtime Action** trying to find one. There is no guarantee that they will be successful. Once a question is posed and an appropriate **Source** has been identified, the **Warden** should provide any **Milestones** and associated **Costs**.

Questions

As always, the question must come from an experience that occurred during play.

Examples:

- "Where is the **Lost Temple of East Nipoor**?"
- "Who in **Fortune City** might know how to crack an ancient vault?"
- "Where can I find the cure to **curly sickness**?"

Sources

A **Source** is a person, place, faction, or entity that holds either a part or whole answer that the character seeks. They can be NPCs, Factions, spirits, or even other PCs.

Examples:

- **Kewr the Mouth**, a frequent contact for the **Conclave of Merchants**. Despite their excellent relationship with this faction, asking for help in an illicit activity might come at a high cost.
- A **Woodwose** who makes his home deep in the **Forest of Knives**. The party encountered him in an earlier expedition and the meeting did not end well. Still, he is said to know the nature of every herb and their healing properties.
- The **Temple of Puppets**, a nomadic circus troupe who have

travelled the known and unknown lands. The party assisted one of their members during the **Rain of Fire**, when even the creatures of the Wood were preparing to flee their homes. If anyone has heard of forgotten places, it's them.

Training

A character can improve their skills with an item or ability, with clear narrative or mechanical results. They might be interested in dealing greater damage with a particular weapon, decreasing their chances of getting lost in rough weather, or learning to read the languages of the ancients. A PC might spend multiple **Downtime Actions** sparring with a particular weapon, improving their skills week by week. Or they may need to travel to the home of a distant sage, improving themselves through short but intense study.

The player must describe precisely what they'd like to improve and a **Master** whom they might train with. And of course, the character's inspiration to improve should come from an experience in play. The **Warden** should provide any **Milestones** and associated **Costs**.

Examples:

- **The Two-Handed Parry:** When fighting with one hand free, a PC's HP temporarily increases by 1d4. The party took on a hireling from the **Cratered Lands**, whose fighters emphasize avoiding enemy attacks. She has agreed to train anyone who can best her in hand to hand combat.
- **Herbology:** Given proper ingredients, a PC can create a **Healing Salve** (restores 4 STR) as a **Downtime Action**. After receiving care from an elderly herbalist in the **Verdant Glades**, the wounded PC asked to be trained in the healing arts. The **Master** has agreed, but asked that they collect three rare herbs before training can begin.
- **Troutmaster:** When taking the Supply **Action**, **Rations** gathered near cold freshwater sources increase by one step (e.g. 1d4 becomes 1d6). The party escorted a stranded naturalist from the famously dreadful **Silver Wastes** safely back to the city. As thanks, she has offered to train a PC to identify and capture a common lakefish that frequents colder waters.

Strengthening Ties

A character fosters a connection with an NPC or Faction in the game world. First, they must identify the entity with whom they wish to strengthen ties, as well as a specific **intent** (e.g., building trust, mending a friendship, seeking membership in a Faction, forming an alliance, and so on). The **Warden** then provides concrete measures (described as **Milestones** and **Costs**) that the PC can undertake to advance the relationship. With each completed **Milestone**, the **Warden** describes how the PC's relationship has grown or changed.

Examples:

- After returning from an unsuccessful delve into the **Roots**, a PC discovers that they'd unknowingly brought along a stowaway: an eyeless devourer, barely hatched. They decide to keep the creature and train it in secret.
- During a play session, a PC becomes friendly with an agent of the **Order of the Helm**. Impressed by the Order's values, the PC asks what the requirements are to join.
- An agent for a powerful faction dies during the **Battle of Frogs**

while under the party's care. Now those responsible wish to provide redress, so that the party can once again perform tasks for that faction.

Marketplace

| All prices are in gold pieces

Armor

Shield (+1 Armor)	10
Helmet (+1 Armor)	10
Gambeson (+1 Armor)	15
Brigandine (1 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Chainmail (2 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	40
Plate (3 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	60

Weapons

Dagger, Cudgel, Sickle, Staff, etc. (d6 damage)	5
Spear, Sword, Mace, Axe, Flail, etc. (d8 damage)	10
Halberd, War Hammer, Long Sword, etc. (d10 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Sling (d6 damage)	5
Bow (d6 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Crossbow (d8 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	30

Transport

Cart (+4 slots, <i>bulky</i>)	30
Wagon (+8 slots, slow)	200
Horse (+4 slots)	75
Mule (+6 slots, slow)	30
Carriage Seat	5
Ship's Passage	10

Upkeep & Recovery

Room & Board (per night)	10
Private Room & Board (fits 4)	35
Stable & Feed (per night)	5
Medical Healing	50
Rations (3 uses)	10
Animal Feed (3 uses, <i>bulky</i>)	5

Hirelings (per day)

Alchemist	30
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Animal Handler	5
Blacksmith	15
Bodyguard	10
Local Guide	5
Lockpick	10
Navigator	10
Sailor	5
Scholar	20
Tracker	5
Trapper	5
Veteran Bodyguard	20

Gear

Air Bladder	5
Antitoxin	20
Bandages (3 uses)	30
Bathing Goods (Soap, Perfume, etc.)	5
Book	50
Caltrops	10
Card Deck	5
Chain (10ft)	10
Chalk (<i>petty</i>)	1
Chest	25
Chisel	5
Common Agents (Glue, Grease, etc.)	10
Common Tools (Hammer, Shovel, etc.)	10
Compass	75
Complex Instruments (Bagpipes, Fiddle, etc.)	50
Containers (Sack, Waterskin, etc.)	10
Cooking Gear (Pots, Utensils, etc.)	10
Costume Gear (Face Paint, Disguise)	15
Dowsing Rod	15
Expeditionary Gear (Climbing Spikes, Pulley, etc.)	10
Fire Oil	10
Fishing Rod	10
Games (Cards, Dice, etc.)	10
Gloves (<i>petty</i>)	20
Grappling Hook	25
Lantern	10
Mirror	5
Net	10
Oil Can (6 uses)	10
Outdoor Comfort (Blanket, Hammock, etc.)	10
Parchment (3 uses)	10
Pole (10ft)	5
Repellent (Wolfsbane, Mugwort, etc.)	10
Rope (25ft)	5

Sedative	30
Sewing Kit	20
Simple Instruments (Pipes, Lute, etc.)	10
Smoking Pipe (<i>petty</i>)	15
Specialized Tools (Ink, etc.)	20
Spiked Boots	15
Spyglass	40
Tent (fits 2, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Thieving Tools (Lockpick, Metal File, etc.)	25
Torch (3 uses)	5
Trap (d6 STR damage)	35
Whistle (<i>petty</i>)	15
Wilderness Clothes (Poncho, Cloak, etc.) (<i>petty</i>)	15

Combat

Introduction

Combat in Cairn is fast, hectic, and often lethal. In addition, the rules of combat are unique in a few key ways:

- **Side Initiative:** With the exception of the first round (when PCs must first save DEX to secure their turn), both the PCs and their opponents take turns acting together. The results of a side's individual actions occur simultaneously.
- **Attacks Automatically Hit:** Combatants typically deal damage to their targets automatically, without rolling to see whether an attack "hits." When multiple attackers target the same foe, only the highest dice result is used in the attack.
- **Hit Protection and Scars:** Hit Protection acts as a measurement of skill, stamina, resilience, and luck. It also refills automatically when the PC is safe and comfortable. If damage reduces a PC's HP to exactly 0, they receive a *Scar*, which can yield both positive and negative consequences.
- **Critical Damage:** Damage that reduces a target's HP below zero is subtracted from their STR by the amount of damage remaining. The target must then immediately make a STR save to avoid taking Critical Damage, using their new STR score. On a fail, the target is defeated.

Example

After days of stepping through endless muck and gloom, the party has finally found the barrow belonging to the Cutlass King, the notorious bandit of a bygone age.

Warden: *"Finally, you reach the point marked on your map, and in the early morning light, the barrow's entrance becomes visible through the thick mist. But as the rolling fog begins to clear, you see a flash of colorful movement near the tomb's entrance."*

Freya: *"Nothing is ever easy, is it? That must be our dear friends from the Ursine Conclave, trying to steal our thunder!"*

Lucius: *"Come now, we don't know that there is an immediate danger. Right?"*

Wolfram: *"It doesn't matter; we must be prepared for whatever comes next. Keep your weapons down, and I'll shout. Perhaps we can avoid bloodshed yet."*

Warden: *"You bark a traditional warning in the direction of the barrow. There is no immediate response, then only a snicker. They appear to be laughing at you! Moments later, three figures step out of the mist and directly into your line of view, each brandishing a weapon. The largest of the three grins as he wields a two-handed war ax, and the other two (a man and woman who are clearly siblings) carry identical swords. Everyone roll a DEX save to see if you can act before they do."*

Wolfram, Lucius, and Freya each save DEX to see whether they can take a turn in the first round. Wolfram and Freya succeed, but Lucius does not.

Lucius: *"Well, shoot. I guess I fumbled my cane sword in all the excitement?"*

Warden: *"Indeed. Alright, Wolfram and Freya, each of you can move and take one action this turn. Assuming they survive, your three opponents will then have a chance to retaliate. Then it will be the PCs' turn to act, including Lucius."*

Wolfram: *"I don't have my crossbow ready, so I'm going to go after the big one with my silver knife. If we can take him down, the others might flee."*

Freya: *"Hey, that was my plan as well! Why don't we both go after him?"*

Wolfram and Freya each make individual attack rolls, but only the highest number counts as damage against the large man [8 HP, 15 STR, 7 DEX, 9 WIL, battleaxe (d10)]. Wolfram rolls a 4, and Freya a 5 and a 1 for each dagger respectively.

Warden: *"You each rush the man with the war ax. He easily sidesteps Wolfram's initial jab but nearly isn't quick enough for Freya! He is nearly eviscerated as her twin daggers slice the air where he stood only a millisecond before. That was a close one!"*

Freya: *"Thanks. That isn't much comfort though."*

It is now the opponents' turn to attack or take an action. Although the description of these events is delivered consecutively, the results happen roughly at the same time. The Warden rolls an attack die for each enemy combatant, targeting each PC only once. The large man rolls a d10 but deals only 3 damage against Freya, while his associates each roll a d6, dealing 1 and a 6 damage against Wolfram and Lucius respectively. As the Warden narrates the results, each player records any lost HP or STR on their character sheet.

Warden: *"Now your opponents will get a crack at it. The large man swings his ax at Freya, but it misses, leaving a wide gap between her and the ax edge. You don't know if you'll be so lucky next time, however. Next, the shorter man stabs at Wolfram, who is the closer of the three. Luckily, the man's blade only glances off his armor. Now on to the man's sister, who nearly takes Lucius's head off with her blade."*

Somehow the blade doesn't draw blood but instead knocks him back so hard he nearly keels over, and his vision is filled with bright lights and sparkling things."

Lucius: "Ouch. I think that takes me to exactly 0 HP. I should check the Scars table, right?"

Warden: "Yes, and you'll need to reference how much HP you lost in the attack. Now let's see... You had 6 HP but no armor, and you took 6 damage in the attack. That means you should receive a **Reorienting Head Wound!**"

Lucius: "You sound a little too excited about this. OK, it says I need to roll 1d6... I got a 3, which indicates DEX. Now I need to roll 3d6, and if the total is greater than my current Dexterity score, I get to keep it, right? Alright... hey, a 14! That's slightly higher than what I have already! Maybe getting knocked in the head isn't all that bad?"

Warden: "Perhaps. One point fewer and you'd have been diseased, and one point greater and you'd lose your hearing for a while. Write down your new DEX score. You really are lucky, you know that? Anyway, it's now time for the PCs to act again."

Wolfram: "I shall riposte against the shorter man!"

Freya: "I'm going to take another swing at the big fella."

Lucius: "I am going to try and stab that woman with my cane sword."

Wolfram rolls a d6, dealing 2 damage to the shorter man, who has enough HP to absorb the attack. Freya rolls a d6 for each of her daggers, dealing a 1 and a 3. She keeps only the higher die, and the large man is able to absorb the damage, taking his HP down to 0 (but only PCs gain Scars). Lucius rolls a 6 against the woman [5 HP, 11 STR, 8 DEX, 14 WIL]. She loses 1 point of STR in the attack and so must then roll a Critical Damage save using her new STR score.

Warden: "Wolfram, you stab at the shorter man, but he deftly avoids your attack! Freya, your daggers slice at the large man with impressive speed and intensity, and it's clear that you've put him on the defensive, as you can see the sweat begin pouring down the sides of his head. He is running out of steam! Lucius, your cane sword pierces the woman in the stomach! She makes a STR save to see if she can stay in the fight. She rolls a 13, a fail! She goes down!"

This is the first casualty of the fight, so the woman's allies must make a WIL save to continue or flee. The Warden rolls using the leader's WIL, and he fails!

Warden: "The short man sees his sister fall and screams a cry of anguish. He drops his sword and commands the larger man to drop his ax. 'Please,' he begs. 'I don't care about whatever is in that barrow. I beg of you: have mercy. Save my sister, if you have the means.'"

Wolfram: "My order takes mercy on all folk willing to forge a new path. If we save your sister with our skills and resources, will you vow to pledge yourself to a life of piety, poverty, and kindness?"

Warden: "The shorter man nods, then rushes to his sister. The larger man only smiles, then says, 'I ain't swearin' nothin'. But I do what he says, so long as he pays. Just let me keep my ax.'"

The party bandage up the woman, stabilizing her. Had they not, she would have bled out within the hour. Now out of danger, the PCs take a quick swig of water and regain their lost HP. Lucius tries to impress Freya by showing off the new battle scar on his eyebrow, but it doesn't work.

Wolfram: *"Alright, that's all sorted then. You lot make your way back to town, and we'll convene later. For now, we've got business with this Cutlass King I've read so much about."*

Saves

Overview

When To Save

There are three common scenarios in which a player character should save:

- When avoiding the negative outcome of a risky action.
- When acting in opposition to another player character, NPC, or creature.
- When aiding one or more characters in a risky action.

Save Principles

- When in doubt, ask whether the party has the time, resources, skills, or advantage to overcome a problem. If the answer is "no," then a save is usually warranted. If the answer is "I don't know," then a roll with the Die of Fate may be necessary.
- Feel free to say "no," but remember to offer an alternative. If the party cannot proceed due to circumstances beyond their control, give them another option to consider.
- Character death should never come as a surprise. If the risk is so great that the outcome might be fatal, make sure the player understands what they're getting into.
- Always provide multiple viable options for the PCs to choose from. The more choices, the more interesting the situation becomes.
- The outcome of a save need not be a simple binary. You can tailor the results based on the totality of input: the effort, forethought, resources, and skill that went into the roll.
- Be transparent with players. This doesn't mean revealing all of the world's secrets, but provide each player with the maximum information their character might have.
- Avoid requiring a dice roll whenever possible. If a PC can solve a problem using purely narrative components, *do not ask for a roll*.
- Replace multiple dice rolls with a single dice throw. Simplifying results to a single roll can increase tension while maximizing player input.

Traditional Saves

Strength

Wolfram dashes through the underground jail cell, a bundle of cloth held tightly to his chest. Lucius and Freya are right behind, fighting off a very large guard and his pet wolf.

Wolfram: *"Remember, they are innocents! They don't need to die!"*

Freya: *"Sorry, I can't hear you through the barks and snarling!"*

Warden: *"Suddenly, the guard stops and whistles, recalling his pet. He then pulls on a lever behind him, and a loud grating sound starts emanating from the other side of the hallway to the East. Then you see what he's done: a thick iron gate is coming down from the ceiling. If it closes, you'll be locked in this section of the jail! Wolfram, you can probably make it through without any risk. Lucius and Freya will need to each make DEX saves in order to make it."*

Wolfram: *"I'm going to stop and hold the gate for as long as I can. What do I risk?"*

Warden: *"The gate is strong. It might break your bones, or you might get stuck underneath."*

Wolfram: *"I toss the bundle through to the other side, then take up a position to grab onto it. Lucius, Freya, you two run ahead. I've got this."*

| Lucius and Freya agree, and Wolfram rolls a 13: a success!

Warden: *"You groan as the iron bars press down against your arms and shoulders. Just as you feel like the gate might crush you in two, Lucius and Freya jog past and into safety. You step back and the gate collapses onto the stone floor with such force that the mechanism itself breaks. There is no going back now! The large guard isn't getting through either, though."*

Wolfram: *"It's just as I've always said: 'Through strength, there is virtue.' Or was it, 'There is virtue in strength?' Ah, anyway... Hey, wait for me!"*

Dexterity

| Freya crouches atop the rafters of a decrepit tavern, spying on a gang of heavily-armed thugs below.

Warden: *"After twenty minutes of cramped discomfort, the care and caution you put into this venture are finally rewarded as one of the men below speaks aloud the location of their hideout. Your mission is complete! What do you do now?"*

Freya: *"I need to skedaddle without these jokers knowing I was ever here. Does it look like they are nearly finished?"*

Warden: *"Actually, one of them is pulling out a deck of cards, and the others are nodding in approval. It looks like they'll be here for a while yet."*

Freya: *"Rats. Well, no time like the present, right? I'm going to sneak back the way I came."*

Warden: *"That's fine, but when you passed earlier there was no one here. That is no longer the case! You'll need to make a DEX save to avoid detection."*

| Freya rolls a 16: a fail!

Warden: *"As you crest the final beam, it creaks. All six of the men look up and see you leap into the crawlspace leading out of the main hall and into the kitchens. They didn't get a bead on your face, but they know you're up there! They shout and draw their weapons."*

Freya: *"I have one smoke bomb left, and I plan on using it. I'm going to drop into the kitchens to find a pot. If I recall correctly, water makes the smoke go crazy..."*

WIL

Lucius has been captured after helping a client try to break into the ancient vault of Der Thunn. In a sudden glut of courage, he allowed himself be taken so that the others could escape.

Wolfram: *"Pity about Lucius. But we have to deliver our client to the vault immediately. We can rescue him after."*

Freya: *"I am NOT leaving him behind. You should still go, but I'm going to get him out. I'm a cutpurse, so I have friends everywhere, right? Or perhaps there's some kind of thieves' cant I can use to make connections here?"*

Warden: *"Indeed. You can spend the night trying to make connections among your kind, if you like."*

The party splits up, and Freya learns what she needs to from a local fence. (It costs her one of the Twins, and she is not happy about it). Lucius is awaiting his sentence in a jail beneath the constabulary.

Warden: *"In the dim light of the early dawn, you notice a note slipped through the street vent. It reads, 'Speak the following, and you will be free: 'The Pale Man Longs To Die.' You have but one chance."*

Lucius: *"...What? OK. Someone gave this to me? And I have to speak it aloud... but at the right time, or to the right person?"*

Warden: *"You hear footsteps as the jailer approaches. He jingles his keys as if he intends to open your cell. What do you do?"*

Lucius: *"OK! This is not the right person, I think. Perhaps I'll talk to someone higher up?"*

Warden: *"He opens your cell and beckons for you to come out."*

Lucius: *"Hello friend! Might I speak to your superior? I have some important news that might be very interesting to them..."*

Warden: *"The jailer smirks as he unlocks raises a pair of manacles."*

Lucius: *"THE PALE MAN LONGS TO DIE!"*

Warden: *"The jailer stops in his tracks, then lowers the manacles. He nods once, then gestures that you follow him."*

Lucius: *"Well, that was lucky. What is this, some code for jailers? Executioners? Well, whatever it is, I'm following."*

Warden: *"The jailer guides you into the darkness of the jail, far from the light. As he reaches the far wall, he taps three times on a stone high above his head. After a moment, the wall swings inward, and the guard walks confidently inside, where a dark-haired woman waits at a desk. She smiles at you and gestures that you sit at the chair across from her."*

Lucius: *"Uh oh. Can I go back to my cell, please? I kid, I kid. I take a seat."*

Warden: *The jailor leaves as you take a seat. The room is small, with only one door on the other side of the woman. A very large man stands outside, his head visible through a small window on the door. The woman smiles again, saying, 'Welcome Mr... Well, it doesn't matter. There is only one reason you are here. You've spoken a code known only to thieves and scoundrels. And which one are you, I wonder?'"*

Lucius: *"What happens now? I don't have anything to barter... Except for perhaps the truth? But that means I have to make a WIL save, right? So that I seem 'convincing?'"*

Warden: *"You'd need to make a WIL save even if you weren't telling the truth. You're definitely the most at risk here, and despite your experience as a charlatan, you think she can probably see through any lie. She and you might not be so different."*

Lucius: *"OK. Madam: I'll be straight with you. My friends and I are here to sneak into the vault of Der Thunn. I only learned of that phrase a few minutes ago. I believe one of my friends (a cutpurse named Freya, you might know her) left me that note. If you set me free, I'll be sure to mention... what's your name, again?"*

Warden: *"Katja. And please, tell me everything."*

Lucius describes the party's , and their efforts so far. He makes a WIL save. He rolls a 5, a success! Katja is convinced of his sincerity.

Warden *"As she listens to your story, Katja frowns, then finally smiles. 'Alright, alright, I believe you. Let's make a deal! You introduce me to this "client" of yours whom you've so kindly escorted into my town, and I'll make sure no one is watching while you slip away. But we have to go right now, before this place implodes. And if that happens, even I can't guarantee your safety..."*

An hour later, Lucius finds Freya, but not the others. She explains that Wolfram and their client have already left for the vault. She agrees to take them there, but says that she needs to make a quick stop first. Something about reclaiming one of her daggers...

Opposed Saves

The party has cornered their opponents (two Bandits and their Hobgoblin chief) against a steep cliff side. Lucius and Wolfram are able to take their turns right away, but Freya failed her initial DEX save and has to go after their opponents. As her friends take on each of their smaller foes, she only narrowly avoids getting her head bashed in by the Hobgoblin!

Freya: *"I don't think I can survive another bout with their leader, so I'm going to try and knock him off the cliff!"*

Warden: *"You are most at risk in this situation, meaning that if you try and push him, you will need to make the appropriate save!"*

Freya: *"And if I fail, I go off the cliff, right? Alright.. I think I can do this. But just in case, I'm going to make sure I'm wearing my Catring!"*

Freya rolls a STR save to try and grapple the Hobgoblin and toss him off the cliff. She rolls a 17, a fail!

Warden: *"Their leader picks you up and flings you backward, sending you careening off the cliff. Fortunately the Catring activates its final charge, and you are able to gracefully catch a tree branch jutting off the mountainside 10ft below. It will take you two turns to climb back up, or you'll need to make a DEX save to do it quickly."*

Freya: *"Damn. Well, hopefully my comrades will fare well enough without me until I return..."*

Aiding an Ally

The party have just arrived at the entrance to the second level of a long-forgotten mountain tomb. Freya leads the group, followed by Lucius, with Wolfram taking up the rear. Wolfram holds a lit torch, but the others have their hands free.

Warden: *"The path to the North veers over a twisted archway positioned atop a dark chasm. To the East, a rocky path leads downward into the murk below. What do you do?"*

Wolfram: *"Our quarry is said to be at the top of this blasted place! I think we should press on to the North."*

Warden: *"The rest of you agree? Alright, then. Assuming you continue with the same marching orders..."*

Wolfram: *"Wait! Let me go first. My Order can reveal that which is hidden, and I feel something sinister lies ahead in the darkness. I will take the lead, stepping as cautiously as possible, my Voidglass Shard at the ready."*

Warden: *"Wolfram, you carefully start across the bridge, which moans and creaks with each step. It feels solid beneath your feet, though. As the party reaches the midway point, the ground begins to shudder violently, then blossoms with cracks. It looks like it's going to collapse from behind!"*

Wolfram: *"If we run to the opposite side, does it look like we can make it safely?"*

Warden: *"You and Lucius are the farthest ahead and likely the least at risk. But Freya is last and will need to make a DEX save to arrive there safely."*

Freya: *"You just had to take the lead, didn't you, Wolfie? I have a rope. Do I have time to toss it to one of the others?"*

Warden: *"Yes, you can do that. Wolfram has his hands full, so Lucius is your best bet. You can easily throw a rope to him, but a STR save will be required. As you will be the most at risk, you will need to make the save."*

Freya: *"A friend and a rope still seems like a good deal to me. Let's do it!"*

Freya rolls a 5: a success!

Warden: *"As the bridge collapses, Wolfram and Lucius dash to the opposite side with Freya right behind. Just as the ground disappears beneath her feet, she tosses Lucius her rope. As the bridge collapses behind her, she slams into the wall, hanging onto the rope for dear life. Slowly, she climbs along the wall, straining to reach the ledge a few feet above her. Finally, she pulls herself onto the dusty floor."*

Freya: "That was fun. What's next?"

Knowledge And Perception

Introduction

Cairn differs from many modern roleplaying games by not including mechanics for knowledge or expertise. Instead, it is assumed that a character has the necessary knowledge so long as it can be justified in the fiction. Similarly, there are no mechanics that govern a character's perception or ability to "detect" important details in their environment. Instead, the Warden should provide unlimited relevant information about every detail a character can perceive with their basic senses.

Knowledge

Character knowledge is limited only by what can be explained by elements in the fiction. If it is known that a PC comes from an impoverished background and learned how to survive by any means necessary, then their player may argue that their character is better able to track down a notable NPC hiding in the slums. They may know whom to speak to and what sorts of trades might be required to collect the information they need about their target's whereabouts.

If a character has no justifiable knowledge of a subject, then they simply do not know anything about it! However, the Warden may decide to roll the **Die of Fate** to determine if the character has a chance of knowing *something*. The higher the result, the more they might (reasonably) know.

Relics

When a character first acquires a Relic they are not familiar with, they can either spend time learning more about it (using a Downtime action) or experiment with it. The latter carries some dangers and may even require a successful WIL save to avoid negative consequences. However, it is often more interesting to allow the player to ask as many questions as they like about it and (eventually) to simply *tell them how it works*.

Perception

When informing the players of what their PCs can perceive, the Warden should provide maximal sensory information pertaining to the objects, characters, dangers, and interactive elements in the given situation. Consider what can be gained by limiting what the PCs know or do not know. Do secrets help create interesting choices and decision points? Do they raise interesting questions? Do they give the players a sense of control over their own actions? The answer to these questions is almost always an emphatic *No*.

Players should feel that the consequences of their character's actions are *earned*, and that they are *deserved*, even if the results aren't always in their favor. True agency comes from providing the players

with everything they need to know to make an interesting decision, even if that is simply asking a question about what their character might perceive.

Take for example the following keyed location:

A colony of **bees** furiously circles a massive hive hanging from the branch of a large oak tree. A **man** observes in the shadows beneath the tree, and a rusted **sword** lies on the ground not far from the tree.

- **Bees:** Their buzzing is nearly deafening, creating a wall of sound around the tree.
 - The hive is dripping with honey. It is delicious, and mundane.
 - Any attempt to take honey from the hive is met with an aggressive response from the colony [3 HP, 3 STR, 12 DEX, 4 WIL, sting (d6), *detachment*].
- **Man:** Leans against a long staff, his gaze fixed on the hive. He appears unfazed by the swarm.
 - The man is a magical illusion created by the beekeeper as a means to drive away any potential predators. He will not react to any direct stimuli.
 - If the hive is damaged in any way, the man will scream very loudly, then disappear.
- **Sword:** Shoe prints in the earth lead towards it but stop abruptly a few feet away.
 - The weapon belongs to the skeleton buried just beneath the earth. It is a regular short sword (d6), strangely preserved.
 - Bloodvines [3 HP, 4 STR, 13 DEX, 1 WIL, tendrils (d6, *blast*)] attack anyone that steps close to the sword, sapping 1 STR per round from their target (STR save to escape after the first round).

In this example, there are three potential dangers: the bees, the man, and the Bloodvine plant. The danger from bees is more obvious, as the PCs can clearly see the danger and are familiar with bees already. The man is an unknown entity and could be friend or foe, while the Bloodvines are hidden and act as a sort of trap. The Warden should therefore communicate exactly what the PCs can see, hear, and smell.

The PCs will likely try to interact with the man first or perhaps ask questions about the sword, as these are both fairly passive ways to engage with the scene. When the PCs realize that the man does not respond, they may try to get a closer look or perhaps toss a rock in his direction (avoiding the hive), and so on. If the PCs ask questions about the sword or try to interact with it, the Warden should tell them about the shoe prints in the grass right away.

If the PCs decide to engage with the bee hive, the Warden should "warn" them with a hint of some kind: the bees begin to fly in a more aggressive manner, or the noise they create gets louder, and so on. It is up to the players whether to ignore the clues in front of them and continue, or to stop and ask questions.

Dungeon Exploration

Principles

- Always clarify what is about to happen. Does that flaming barrel look stable or like it might explode at any minute?
- Regularly restate a character's surroundings, where they are in physical space, and what their senses are detecting.

- Describe obvious threats and NPCs first, followed by any distinct and memorable objects in each room.
- Do not tell characters how they should feel, and only tell them what's happening right now, before their eyes.
- Provide hints about what lies beyond the next corridor, including odors, sounds, and elevation.
- Ensure that the players understand their character's place in the Dungeon Cycle. Remind them who has already moved, who has yet to take an action, and so on.
- The cost of dungeon exploration is paid in turns. If the party spends too long in one place, acts without caution, makes noise, or enters a new area, they risk a roll on the Dungeon Events table. Players should always be made aware of the cost.

Dungeon Exploration Example

Wolfram, Lucius, and Freya have entered the first level of **Ein Eyton**, a forest temple once rumored to house an infamous death cult. Each character has a torch, but only **Wolfram** has one lit. There are no light sources here beyond the Moon in the night sky. The first room is presented as follows:

The Courtyard

A wide courtyard exposed to the **open air**. The **ground** is sandy and rough. **Rubble** is piled near the center of the room. A full-sized **statue** holding a bident is placed in the exact center. A wooden **doorway** to the East is locked with an iron chain. An open stone archway leads towards the West.

- **Air:** The roof has collapsed, letting exterior lighting illuminate the room.
- **Ground:** Glitters in the light. A cursory investigation will reveal that the "sand" is actually pulverized bones.
- **Rubble:** Stone chunks from statues resembling people.
 - A red jewel glints within a tight stone fist.
- **Statue:** One eye socket is empty, in the other is a red jewel.
 - The cult's Death Goddess, marred by time. If the remaining eye is removed, the statue comes to life, slicing the bident in an arc for d6 STR damage. Contact with the bident turns the victim to stone.
 - If the jewel from the nearby rubble is inserted into the statue, nothing happens. If it is removed again, the statue responds accordingly.
- **Doorway:** The door to the Storeroom has nearly rotted away, leaving cracks in the wood. The iron chain is clearly rusted.

Warden "Warden: "You enter a wide courtyard illuminated by moonlight drifting through the collapsed roof. The ground is sandy and sparkles chalk-white in the moonlight. Near the center, rubble piles around a statue of a woman wielding a bident. To the East, a wooden door is closed and chained, while an open archway leads Westward into a dark tunnel. What do you do?"

| **The characters then declare their intended actions.**

Wolfram: "I'll search the room for clues about its purpose, starting with that glittery ground." **Lucius:** "I'll check out the wooden **door**, to see if I can figure out what's on the other side." **Freya:** "I'm going to get a better look at that **statue**. What can I learn without actually getting too close?"

Warden: "Alright, let's start with **Wolfram**. The sand is white, grainy, and clearly not from any beach 'round these parts. Starting at a small lump in the ground, you recognize a half-decayed human skull, meaning that this 'sand' is actually bone! What do you do now?"

Wolfram: "Gross. I'm gonna poke at it a bit with my sword. Is there is anything hidden in the dust? Something valuable, maybe?"

Warden: "No. But you're at least convinced the ground is safe. And that's the end of your turn!"

The Warden then moves to describe another character's actions, as they are happening simultaneously.

Warden: "Let's see what **Lucius** is up to."

Warden: "**Lucius**, the **door** is locked, ancient, and partly rotted away. It bears a rusted iron lock. What do you do now?"

Lucius: "As I have no lockpick, I think I'll put my ear to the door to see what's on the other side."

Warden: "You place an ear on the door, but hear only a faint rustling on the other side."

Lucius: "How busted is the keyhole? Could I see through it? What about the door itself? You said it was rotted."

Warden: "The keyhole is intact, and too dark to look through. You could shine a light through it, or you could use one of the gaps in the door."

Lucius: "That works. I light my **torch** and hold it aloft so that I can see through."

Warden: "**Lucius**, Through the cracks, you can see a gray cement floor. Something gleams on the ground, flickering in the torchlight. It looks like a large, wet footprint!"

Lucius: "Eek! I let the others know."

Warden: "Got it. Now let's see what **Freya** can find out about that statue."

Freya: "Right, remember that I'd like to take a look, but I don't want to get too close."

Warden: "You approach until you are about five feet away from the statue. The face looks chipped away, and one of the eyes is missing entirely. However, embedded in the other is a beautiful red jewel! The statue holds a white bident in its hands. Do you interact with the statue further or move along?"

Freya: "That's just creepy! I want no part in this, at least not until we learn more about what this room was for. I'd like to investigate that rubble you mentioned before."

Warden: "Alright, you move to the rubble adjacent to the statue. It looks extremely heavy and difficult to move. In the light from **Wolfram's** torch, you can see something red and shiny glinting in the cracks of the pile. What do you do?"

Freya: "I investigate further, of course!"

Warden: *"You take a closer look, and spy a red jewel enclosed in a large stone fist. It looks valuable, at least 75gp. It also looks large enough to take up an entire slot!"*

Freya: *"I want it. Can I dig it out easily?"*

Warden: *"The fingers are wrapped around it quite tightly; you'll need to work hard to get it loose or spend an extra turn to extract it quietly. Either choice will likely trigger a dungeon event roll."*

Freya: *"Damn. Fine, I'll do it as quickly as possible, using the edge of my dagger and a block of rubble to pop it out. Noise be damned!"*

Warden: *"Alright, let's see how loud you are..."*

**The Warden then rolls on the Dungeon Events table:
Environment.**

Warden: *"Freya's clanging labor echoes against the exposed walls of the courtyard. The silence is broken by a shingle falling from the east wall, clattering onto the stone floor. Lucius, you hear rustling noises drawing nearer from behind the door! At that exact moment, the jewel comes loose."*

Warden: *"And with that, this cycle is over. What do you all do next?"*

Lucius: *"Um, something's coming. Can we please leave, NOW?"*

Freya: *"I'll quickly put the jewel in my backpack."*

Wolfram: *"I think we should head down that stone archway to the West. We can always circle back to this room on our way out."*

Freya: *"Hang on, what about this jewel I discovered? It looks like it could go in that statue's eye..."*

Lucius: *"What are you, nuts? For all we know that statue will come to life and attack!"*

Freya: *"Or maybe it'll open a secret door?"*

Wolfram: *"Enough, let's just move on for now. There is something on the other side of that door, and I do NOT want to find out what!"*

**The party moves on to the adjoining hall and the
adventure continues.**

Wilderness Exploration

Overview

In Cairn, wilderness exploration and travel is mostly abstract, hand-waving away the minutiae of the journey while still giving the party ample opportunities for interactivity and character agency.

Exploration Example

The party is escorting an NPC between two POIs: a small village situated in the grasslands to a stronghold at the base of an impressive valley. The short journey should only take one day, as travel is limited to *Easy* terrain and is along a clear *Trail* all the way.

At the start of the day, the Warden rolls for the local weather, then adjudicates its potential impacts on the journey that day. It is overcast and breezy (no impact). After each of the following **Wilderness Actions**, the party rolls 1d6 to see if they get lost, and the Warden rolls on the **Wilderness Events Table**.

Day One / Watch One

- The party takes the **Travel** action. *They do not get lost.*
- **Events Table: Sign.** One of the characters looks behind the party and spies something glittering in the distance behind them. It disappears after a few seconds. Could that be a spyglass, reflecting in the sun?

Day One / Watch Two

- The party takes the **Travel** action again, continuing along the same trail and plain. *They do not get lost.*
- **Events Table: Environment.** The weather has worsened in the evening, and as a result, the plain is muddy and the trail harder to follow. The Warden adds 1 Watch to the journey, as the party is forced to slow their march considerably, only reaching the edge of the grasses by nightfall. The party is forced to find shelter in the open plain rather than at their destination in the adjacent valley.

Day One / Watch Three

- The party takes the **Make Camp** action. They set up a hastily-made shelter, and each character consumes a Ration. A lookout rotation is set, dividing the night between all four party members.
- **Events Table: Sign.** The sky clears up enough for the first person on lookout to see a light in the distance, flickering slowly. A campfire! Someone is definitely following them.

Note: the party could have chosen to continue on through the night, but doing so could increase the chance of getting lost and put the party at greater risk!

Bonds and Omens

Introduction

Bonds and Omens provide new player characters with adventure hooks, starting gear, and abilities. And while they are distinct from character Backgrounds, they are equally useful for building a setting, or even a complete adventure!

Bonds

Bonds can often tie a player character to another PC, the setting, and its characters. A PC can resolve a Bond by discovering the truth behind its mysteries or by solving its root cause. In this case, the character should experience Growth of some kind, and the Warden can optionally create a new Bond for the PC. Player characters are not required to resolve their Bonds.

Bonds Should...

- Give a character an item (often *petty*) or a unique ability.
- Encourage character engagement with the implied setting.
- Flesh out a character's history without relying on events tied to specific Backgrounds.
- Provide a character with a quest, opportunity, or plan of action.

Omens

Omens are the seeds of an adventure yet to come, premonitions of a future disaster, or the cause of a problem the characters are currently facing. An Omen is resolved when the characters reveal the truth behind its origin or resolve its dangers. Resolving an Omen should yield Growth of some kind, either for the party as a collective or to an entangled individual. If an Omen is ignored, it should come to pass and wreak whatever havoc it may.

Omens Should...

- Never rely on a specific player character for relevance.
- Always tell the characters something about the setting they did not already know.
- Reveal a pattern or other obvious indicator that something terrible is going on.

Spellbooks

1	Adhere	An object is covered in extremely sticky slime. <i>Adjacent objects stick to the book with great force.</i>
2	Anchor	A strong wire sprouts from your arms, affixing itself to two points within 50ft on each side. <i>If a rope is pulled through the iron loop on its spine, it becomes as heavy as an elephant.</i>
3	Animate Object	An object obeys your commands as best it can. <i>Moldable like clay. Childish laughter sprouts from its pages.</i>
4	Anthropomorphize	An animal either gains human intelligence or human appearance for one day. <i>Whimpers, purrs and growls depending on its treatment.</i>
5	Arcane Eye	You can see through a magical floating eyeball that flies around at your command. <i>Needs a spritz of water to open.</i>
6	Astral Prison	An object is frozen in time and space within an invulnerable crystal shell. <i>Silent, abstract, faces scream in anguish within.</i>
7	Attract	Two objects are strongly magnetically attracted to each other if they come within 10 feet. <i>Nearby compasses spin uselessly.</i>
8	Auditory Illusion	You create illusory sounds that seem to come from a direction of your choice. <i>Produces random and occasionally inopportune sounds throughout the</i>

		day.
9	Babble	A creature must loudly and clearly repeat everything you think. It is otherwise mute. <i>When the text is read aloud, the words of others become unintelligible.</i>
10	Bait Flower	A plant sprouts from the ground that emanates the smell of decaying flesh. <i>Attracts flies.</i>
11	Beast Form	You and your possessions transform into a mundane animal. <i>Covered in thick fur, its edges lined with small teeth.</i>
12	Befuddle	A creature of your choice is unable to form new short-term memories for the duration of the spell. <i>Its contents shift and change each time it is opened.</i>
13	Body Swap	You switch bodies with a creature you touch. If one body dies, the other dies as well. <i>The front cover shows an image of the last creature to read it.</i>
14	Charm	A creature you can see treats you as a friend. <i>Warm to the touch, and smells of roses.</i>
15	Command	A target obeys a single three-word command that does not cause it harm. <i>Grows thinner over time, until finally disappearing forever.</i>
16	Comprehend	You become fluent in all languages for a short while. <i>Drips letters, staining whatever it touches.</i>
17	Cone of Foam	Dense foam sprays from your hand, coating the target. <i>Spongy and moist with a soapy residue.</i>
18	Control Plants	Nearby plants and trees obey you and gain the ability to move at a slow pace. <i>Leaves grow along the spine, and it smells faintly of decay.</i>
19	Control Weather	You may alter the type of weather at will, but you do not otherwise control it. <i>Highly resistant to fire and water damage.</i>
20	Cure Wounds	Restore 1d4 STR per day to a creature you can touch. <i>Smells of vinegar and thyme. Turns red after use.</i>
21	Deafen	All nearby creatures are deafened. <i>Nearby instruments occasionally sound off, as if in protest.</i>
22	Detect Magic	You can see or hear nearby magical auras. <i>Becomes warm to the touch if magic is used nearby.</i>
23	Disassemble	Any of your body parts may be detached and reattached at will, without causing pain or damage. You can still control them. <i>Regenerates any torn or defaced pages.</i>
24	Disguise	You may alter the appearance of one character at will as long as they remain humanoid. Attempts to duplicate other

		characters will seem uncanny. <i>The surface makes a perfect mirror.</i>
25	Displace	An object appears to be up to 15ft from its actual position. <i>Bits of string, clothing, and leaves are sometimes stuffed inside.</i>
26	Earthquake	The ground begins shaking violently. Structures may be damaged or collapse. <i>Sand dribbles from the corners, seemingly without stop.</i>
27	Elasticity	Your body can stretch up to 10ft. <i>Smells of taffy, and is very flexible.</i>
28	Elemental Wall	A straight wall of ice or fire 50ft long and 10ft high rises from the ground. <i>Skin and warmer substances stick to it after use.</i>
29	Filch	A visible item teleports to your hands. <i>An ally's prized possession may occasionally be found tucked between its covers.</i>
30	Fish Lung	A target can breathe underwater until they surface again. <i>Smells strongly of the sea. Attracts wild animals.</i>
31	Flare	A bright ball of energy fires a trail of light into the sky, revealing your location to friend or foe. <i>Faintly glows in complete darkness.</i>
32	Fog Cloud	A dense fog spreads out from you. <i>When submersed in water, the book eventually turns all the liquid to vapor.</i>
33	Frenzy	A nearby creature erupts in a frenzy of violence. <i>Rough, sandpaper cover that destroys any book it touches.</i>
34	Gate	A portal to a random plane opens. <i>A large hole is carved into the center, ending in a void. Items dropped within are never seen again.</i>
35	Gravity Shift	You can change the direction of gravity, but only for yourself. <i>Attaches itself to the largest object nearby.</i>
36	Greed	A creature develops the overwhelming urge to possess a visible item of your choice. <i>The cover changes depending on the owner, subtly hinting at their deepest desires.</i>
37	Haste	Your movement speed is tripled. <i>Pages flip wildly while open. Can cause paper cuts.</i>
38	Hatred	A creature develops a deep hatred of another creature or group and wishes to destroy them. <i>Long term exposure to the book can cause suspicion, paranoia and distrust of others.</i>
39	Hear Whispers	You can hear faint sounds clearly. <i>The reader's voice is amplified for a short period of time afterwards.</i>
40	Hover	An object hovers, frictionless, 2ft above the ground. It can hold up to one humanoid. <i>Floats if dropped.</i>

41	Hypnotize	A creature enters a trance and will truthfully answer one yes or no question you ask it. <i>Eye-catching, swirling spirals don its covers.</i>
42	Icy Touch	A thick ice layer spreads across a touched surface, up to 10ft in radius. <i>Gloves required. Nonflammable.</i>
43	Identify Owner	Letters appear over the object you touch, spelling out the name of the object's owners, if there are any. <i>The book's interior lists the name of its previous owner.</i>
44	Illuminate	A floating light moves as you command. <i>When held in light, the pages become a prism of vibrant rainbows.</i>
45	Invisible Tether	Two objects within 10ft of each other cannot be moved more than 10ft apart. <i>Its pages are not attached by glue or thread, yet stay together nonetheless.</i>
46	Knock	A nearby mundane or magical lock unlocks loudly. <i>Locked. A new owner "produces" the key after their next meal.</i>
47	Leap	You jump up to 10ft high, once. <i>When thrown, it just keeps going.</i>
48	Liquid Air	The air around you becomes swimmable. <i>Floats of its own volition, bouncing off of whatever it touches.</i>
49	Magic Dampener	All nearby magical effects have their effectiveness halved. <i>Relics within 100ft of the spellbook cannot be recharged.</i>
50	Manse	A sturdy, furnished cottage appears for hours. You can permit and forbid entry to it at will. <i>If left inside, both the book and the cottage vanish forever.</i>
51	Marble Craze	Your pockets are full of marbles and will refill every 30 seconds. <i>When jostled, makes a playful rattling sound.</i>
52	Masquerade	A character's appearance and voice becomes identical to those of a character you touch. <i>Extended use causes the owner to develop unconscious yet noticeable tics.</i>
53	Miniaturize	A creature you touch is shrunk down to the size of a mouse. <i>The text is ludicrously, comically large.</i>
54	Mirror Image	An illusory duplicate of yourself appears and is under your control. <i>Over time, the owner begins to question who is the original, and who is the duplicate.</i>
55	Mirrorwalk	A mirror becomes a gateway to another mirror that you looked into today. <i>Will not open unless the owner politely knocks on the cover.</i>
56	Multiarm	You temporarily gain an extra arm. <i>After use, the caster is wracked with phantom limb syndrome for a day.</i>

57	Night Sphere	A 50ft-wide sphere of darkness displaying the night sky appears before you. <i>Displays a prominent constellation on its cover.</i>
58	Objectify	You become any inanimate object between the size of a grand piano and an apple. <i>The owner experiences intense pareidolia for days after use.</i>
59	Ooze Form	You become a living jelly. <i>Slowly drips an acid that eventually eats away anything it touches.</i>
60	Pacify	A creature near you has an aversion to violence. <i>Smells of jasmine and incense. Attracts children.</i>
61	Passage	Creates a temporary path through wood, stone or brick. <i>An object dropped on top of the book inevitably falls through the other side.</i>
62	Phobia	A nearby creature becomes terrified of an object of your choice. <i>Over time, haunting, abstract art begins to fill its pages.</i>
63	Pit	A pit 10ft wide and 10ft deep opens in the ground. <i>A standard piton can be safely stored in its spine.</i>
64	Primal Surge	A creature rapidly evolves into a future version of its species. <i>The owner is haunted by strange visions of their own ancestors.</i>
65	Push/Pull	An object of any size is pulled directly towards you or pushed directly away from you with the strength of one man. <i>Any force against the book is comically amplified.</i>
66	Raise Dead	A skeleton rises from the ground to serve you. They are incredibly stupid and can only obey simple orders. <i>The owner becomes more and more fascinated with bones after each use.</i>
67	Raise Spirit	The spirit of a nearby corpse manifests and will answer 1 question. <i>The answers (but not their questions) are forever inscribed in its pages.</i>
68	Read Mind	You can hear the surface thoughts of nearby creatures. <i>Long-term possession can cause the reader to mistake the thoughts of others as their own.</i>
69	Repel	Two objects are strongly magnetically repelled from each other within 10 feet. <i>Closed by two powerful straps that spring open at inopportune times.</i>
70	Scry	You can see through the eyes of a creature you touched earlier today. <i>The owner's eyes turn milky-white for an hour after use.</i>
71	Sculpt Elements	Inanimate material behaves like clay in your hands. <i>Slowly decays on contact with wood or cloth. Bury in dirt or submerge in water to refresh.</i>

72	Sense	Choose one kind of object (key, gold, arrow, jug, etc). You can sense the nearest example. <i>The book's previous owner is always aware of the book's current location.</i>
73	Shield	A creature you touch is protected from mundane attacks for one minute. <i>Bound in rusty ring-mail and is quite heavy. If held, provides +1 Armor.</i>
74	Shroud	A creature you touch is invisible until they move. <i>Invisible to any but the book's current owner.</i>
75	Shuffle	Two creatures you can see instantly switch places. <i>If stolen but not yet read, it reappears wherever its owner last left it.</i>
76	Skillful Repair	You make minor repairs to a nonliving object. <i>Sewn from the vellum of one hundred books, no two pages are alike.</i>
77	Sleep	A creature you can see falls into a light sleep. <i>Soft as a pillow, but yields only fitful sleep.</i>
78	Slick	Every surface in a 30ft radius becomes extremely slippery. <i>Gloves are required for handling, lest the book is dropped in a most comical fashion.</i>
79	Smoke Form	Your body becomes a living smoke that you can control. <i>Smells of campfire. The pages cannot be burnt, but are very sensitive to moisture.</i>
80	Sniff	You can smell even the faintest traces of scents. <i>Expresses a strong odor detectable only by its owner.</i>
81	Snuff	The source of any mundane light you can see is instantly snuffed out. <i>If left in one place for long periods, nearby light sources eventually dim, then finally go out.</i>
82	Sort	Inanimate items sort themselves according to categories you set. <i>Rights itself when dropped or thrown.</i>
83	Spellsaw	A whirling blade flies from your chest, clearing any plant material in its way. It is otherwise harmless. <i>Wrapped in stained leather, it should be oiled at least once a month.</i>
84	Spider Climb	You can climb surfaces like a spider. <i>New cobwebs must be pushed aside prior to each use. They are hard to remove.</i>
85	Swarm	You become a swarm of crows, rats, or piranhas. You can only be harmed by blast attacks. <i>Easily broken into a dozen distinct parts that slowly move towards one another over time.</i>
86	Target Lure	An object you touch becomes the target of any nearby spell. <i>Attracts all manner of magical creatures, spell leaks, and scrying.</i>

87	Telekinesis	You may mentally 1 move item under 60lbs. <i>The owner can summon the book through mental command alone (WIL save or become deprived afterwards).</i>
88	Telepathy	Two creatures can hear each other's thoughts, no matter how far apart. <i>The holder can hear (but not respond) to the thoughts of whoever last possessed it, and vice versa.</i>
89	Teleport	An object or person you can see is transported from one place to another in a 50ft radius. <i>Can be destroyed to create a portal to another dimension.</i>
90	Thicket	A thicket of trees and dense brush up to 50ft wide suddenly sprouts up. <i>Wrapped in vines that must be destroyed again with each use.</i>
91	Time Control	Time in a 50ft bubble slows down or increases by 10% for 30 seconds. <i>Alternates its appearance as either impossibly old or freshly written.</i>
92	True Sight	You see through all nearby illusions. <i>Cannot be concealed by magic, and sticks out like a sore thumb.</i>
93	Upwell	A spring of seawater appears. <i>Hardened leather bindings caked in salt and living barnacles.</i>
94	Vision	You completely control what a creature sees. <i>An unnerving, lidless eye graces the front cover.</i>
95	Visual Illusion	A silent, immobile, room-sized illusion of your choice appears. <i>Filled with rich, colorful pages very much like a children's bedtime story.</i>
96	Ward	A silver circle 50ft across appears on the ground. Choose one species that cannot cross it. <i>The covers are decorated with bizarre, otherworldly creatures with thousands of eyes.</i>
97	Web	Your wrists shoot thick webbing. <i>The text is alien, yet somehow intelligible, for it is the language of dreams.</i>
98	Widget	A primitive version of a drawn tool or item appears before you and disappears after a short time. <i>Smells of iron and rust, sweat and effort. Faint sounds of harsh labor emanate from deep within its pages.</i>
99	Wizard Mark	Your finger can shoot a stream of ulfire-colored paint. This paint is only visible to you and can be seen at any distance, even through solid objects. <i>Inside the front cover is a small pocket containing a thin pad of paper, listing the name and date of death of all previous owners.</i>
100	X-Ray Vision	You can see through walls, dirt, clothing, etc. <i>Long-term exposure can cause hair loss, blurry vision, and</i>

fatigue.
